# 2004 Toyota Matrix

$3,800 · 168,000 miles · Private seller · Palmdale, CA

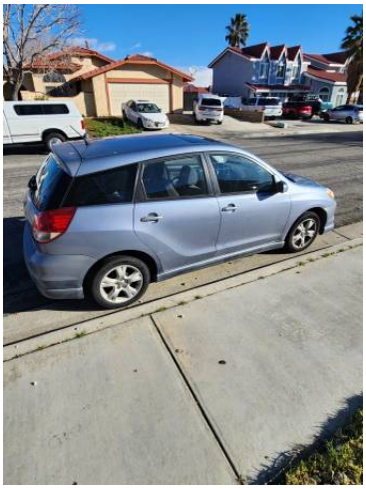
Seller: Private seller

Source: Craigslist

Listing: https://www.craigslist.org/view/d/palmdale-vehicle-for-sale/fDyPgztoaf5UbqhzRrJTjk

Report generated October 26, 2026 · Ridgecrest Car Finder










+ 2 more photos in the app.

| Out-the-door price | Monthly cost to own | Reliability |
|---|---|---|
| **$4,331** | **$375** | **Good** |
| Set a budget in the Cost Calculator tab to compare. | loan + insurance + fuel + repairs + registration | 4/5 · 3 recalls · 138 NHTSA complaints |

## Budget — buying it

| | |
|---|---|
| Vehicle price | $3,800.00 |
| Use tax (9.25%) — paid at DMV | $351.50 |
| Vehicle license fee (0.65% of price) | $24.70 |
| Registration + CHP fee | $108.00 |
| Transportation improvement fee | $32.00 |
| Title transfer | $15.00 |
| Total out-the-door | $4,331.20 |
| + Pre-purchase inspection (you pay the shop) | $150.00 |

California taxes the full price — a trade-in does not reduce sales tax. DMV fees are estimates; the CA DMV fee calculator gives exact amounts.

## Budget — paying for it

| | |
|---|---|
| Down payment | $4,331.20 |
| Amount financed | $0.00 |
| Cash needed up front (down payment + inspection) | $4,481.20 |

Paid in full with your down payment — no loan needed.

## Budget — owning it each month

| | |
|---|---|
| Loan payment | $0.00 |
| Insurance (estimate, liability) | $70.00 |
| Fuel (1,000 mi/mo @ 27 MPG, $4.75/gal) | $175.93 |
| Maintenance & repair reserve | $115.00 |
| Registration renewal (÷12) | $14.56 |
| Total per month | $375.48 |

Running costs without the loan: **$375/mo**. Estimated first-year cost of ownership: **$8,987** (out-the-door + inspection + 12 months of running costs + loan interest).

The repair reserve is set from the reliability rating and mileage: money to set aside, not a forecast.

## Insurance

| Coverage | Typical Ridgecrest range | Estimate used |
|---|---|---|
| Liability only (CA minimum 30/60/15) | $49–$112/mo | $70/mo |
| Full coverage (liability + collision + comprehensive) | $94–$243/mo | $135/mo |

The budget above uses the **liability coverage** estimate ($70/mo). Get real quotes and enter one in the app to replace it.

• Vehicle class: typical car. Estimates assume an adult driver with a clean record; age, record, credit, and coverage limits change the price a lot.

• Ridgecrest is one of the cheapest places in California to insure a car (about $107–110/mo average).

• A lender will require full coverage. On an older, cheap car paid in cash, liability-only can make sense — but you'd pay for your own repairs after an at-fault accident.

• California's minimum (30/60/15) is low; $100k/$300k/$100k liability is commonly recommended.

• Ask about military/government discounts (NAWS China Lake), bundling, and low-mileage discounts.

## Reliability

**Rating: Good (4/5)**

Toyota Matrix = Corolla mechanicals (1.8L 1ZZ-FE, 4-speed auto): among the most durable cheap commuters. Main watch-item on 2003-04 is oil consumption from the piston rings.

NHTSA data for this model year: 3 recalls · 138 owner complaints (18 involving a crash). Most complaints: Power Train (37), Air Bags (35), Vehicle Speed Control (15), Visibility (13), Electrical System (9), Structure (8).

**Known issues for this model**

• Oil burning on some 1ZZ-FE engines (2003-04)

• Sagging/worn engine mounts

• Takata airbag recall (passenger) - confirm done

• Rear hatch struts and A/C wear with age

**Check on this car before buying**

• Pull dipstick - full and clean? Ask how often they add oil

• Blue smoke on cold start

• Run VIN for open Takata recall

• Tire date codes / tread

• A/C cold in Palmdale heat

## Notes

$3,800, 168k mi, automatic, FWD, clean title, blue. Posted 2026-10-21. Owner says well maintained (regular oil changes), brakes and water pump replaced ~7 months ago, straight body, good interior; tires are 'OK' but they suggest replacing. Tags due November - seller will keep them current. Stopped driving it after buying a bigger vehicle.

A Corolla underneath, with a hatchback that fits big catering orders. ~1.5 hr drive from Ridgecrest - text first. Budget ~$400-600 for tires.

## Vetting checklist (0/12 done)

- [ ] Checked KBB/Edmunds fair price
- [ ] Recalls checked / completed
- [ ] Clean title in seller's name
- [ ] Test drive incl. highway & hills
- [ ] No overheating; coolant clean
- [ ] Pre-purchase inspection
- [ ] VIN decoded & matches listing
- [ ] History report (Carfax/AutoCheck/NMVTIS)
- [ ] Valid smog cert (< 90 days)
- [ ] A/C cold after 15+ min
- [ ] Tires OK (tread, dry-rot, DOT date)
- [ ] Written out-the-door price

All costs and insurance figures are estimates for planning, not quotes. Confirm fees with the CA DMV, rates with insurers, and the car's condition with an independent pre-purchase inspection.